

to enhance frame rates during gaming sessions, and the Iceloop cooling system, which boasts a larger heat dissipation area than traditional VC cooling systems.

Benchmark tests underscore the phone's impressive performance. On AnTuTu v10, the POCO F6 scored nearly 1.4 million, making it the second-highest mid-range score recorded, just behind the iQOO Neo9 Pro's 1.63 million. In Geekbench, it achieved top-tier scores, again only bested by the iQOO Neo9 Pro. However, in PCMark Work, the POCO F6 led the pack with a score of 14,634.

In GPU benchmarks, the phone scored a solid 3032 on 3D Mark Wildlife Extreme and performed well in GFXBench, although it didn't surpass the iQOO Neo9 Pro. The POCO F6 excelled in the CPU Throttling Test, maintaining 88 per cent of its peak performance, demonstrating its efficiency under sustained loads.

Beyond synthetic benchmarks, the POCO F6 delivers a smooth and responsive real-world experience. Despite my reservations about HyperOS, with its bloatware and somewhat clunky design, the POCO F6 handled everyday tasks with ease, including web browsing, social media, gaming, and video editing, all without lag or stutter. Gaming performance is equally impressive. Call of Duty: Mobile and Genshin Impact ran flawlessly. Genshin Impact performed smoothly on Medium graphics without significant heat, though there was some throttling at high settings, which is typical even for flagship devices. COD: Mobile played responsively at Very High Graphics with Max frame rate, and Low graphics with Ultra frame rate.

While HyperOS, layered over Android 14, offers high functionality and customisation, its bloatware and UI design hinder the overall experience for me. Nonetheless, POCO's commitment to three years of software updates and four years of security updates is reassuring and aligns with industry standards.

CAMERA

The POCO F6's camera setup marks a significant upgrade over its predecessor. The primary camera now features a Sony IMX882 sensor with both OIS and EIS

support, a notable improvement from the 64 MP Omnivision sensor on the POCO F5. Additionally, there's an 8 MP ultrawide lens, while the previously included 2 MP macro lens has been dropped—a move that won't disappoint many, given the limited utility of such low-resolution cameras. On the front, a new 20 MP Omnivision selfie camera has been introduced.

In optimal lighting conditions, the primary camera of the POCO F6 captures stunning photos with excellent dynamic range and detail retention. Colours are close to natural, and close-up shots exhibit vibrant details with a pleasing natural bokeh effect. Indoor photos, while slightly softer in detail, still look impressive and flattering. Portrait mode has seen significant improvement, with superb edge detection and nearly natural colour reproduction. However, the default beauty mode should be turned off for a more accurate representation of subjects.

Low-light performance of the main camera is commendable, producing impressive results. Although there is a noticeable drop in detail compared to daylight photos, this is primarily evident when zooming in. Lens flare is minimal, though some noise is apparent, particularly in the skies. The ultrawide lens produces decent photos, albeit with some compromises in sharpness. The overall aesthetic is consistent with the primary camera, with a respectable dynamic range. There is some loss of detail in the shadows, but it's not a significant drawback. The 20 MP selfie camera performs well in daylight, delivering good-quality photos, though it struggles in low-light conditions, where the quality noticeably degrades.

BATTERY LIFE

The POCO F6 features a robust 5,000 mAh battery with support for 90 W fast charging, and pleasantly surprises with a 120 W charger included in the box. Notably, the POCO F6 boasts one of the best battery performances in the mid-range segment, thanks in part to the power-efficient Snapdragon 8s Gen 3 processor.

With heavy usage, including extensive benchmarking, photography, and gaming,

the POCO F6 comfortably lasts a full day. By 10 PM, after a demanding day, I still had around 20 per cent of battery remaining. In our 4K video loop test, the phone demonstrated impressive endurance, lasting 16 hours and 33 minutes. Streaming Netflix for half an hour only consumed 3 per cent of the battery, while an hour of using Google Maps drained just 6 per cent. Whether you're a casual user or a gamer, you can expect exceptional battery life from the POCO F6.

Charging speed is another highlight. Using the 120 W charger included in the box, the phone charged from zero to full in just 38 minutes, making it incredibly convenient to charge the phone in a pinch.

VERDICT

The POCO F6 reaffirms POCO's knack for delivering fantastic value, blending top-notch performance with a rich feature set at a great price. It's not just a gaming beast; the POCO F6 shines across the board. The Sony IMX882 primary camera is a big step up, and the 6.67-inch AMOLED display is stunningly vibrant and crisp. Plus, the beefy 5,000 mAh battery easily gets you through a busy day, and the included 120 W charger is a real treat for quick top-ups.

Sure, the lack of expandable storage and some bloatware in HyperOS are minor hiccups, but they hardly overshadow the overall package. The POCO F6 isn't just for gamers. It's a versatile smartphone that hits all the right notes for both power users and casual folks. If you're after a well-rounded phone with killer performance and loads of features, the POCO F6 should definitely be on your radar.

—Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

Chipset: Qualcomm Snapdragon 8s Gen 3 | GPU: Adreno 735 | RAM: 8/12 GB LPDDR5X | Storage: 256/512 GB UFS 4.0 | OS: Android 14, HyperOS | Display: 6.67" AMOLED, 2712 x 1220 pixels, 120 Hz | Display protection: Gorilla Glass Victus | Cameras (rear): 50 MP + 8 MP | Camera (front): 20 MP | Battery capacity: 5,000 mAh | Charging: 90 W | IP rating: IP64 | Weight: 179 g

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